Runs Girl

By Chinelo Okparanta

ADA: (Pg 67+) The year Mama fell sick was the year Njideka confessed to me that she was a runs girl. I should have known. She walked around campus with shiny silk blouses hanging low on her shoulders, her stilettos making tiny dents in the earth. Maybe [Runs Girls] had always been around. Maybe I only noticed them ***that*** year, with their expensive outfits and accessories – money written all over their bodies – because Mama was falling apart, and there was almost nothing I could do.

INTRODUCTION

'Runs Girl' is the Nigerian term for escort. Someone who willing to offer sex or companionship to any man in exchange for material things: expensive clothes, mobile phones or in Ada's case treatment for her dying mother. What would you be willing to do to save the ones you love?

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ADA: It began with pain on the shoulder. Mama decided that for dinner we would have some goat meat in pepper soup, with more than the normal amount of *utazi* leaves. The leaves made the soup bitter. Mama said that the bitterness, in combination with the pepper, would chase the pain away.

But the next day she could barely move her left hand. We should have gone to the hospital straight away, but Mama said to hold off. They would charge us 2,000 naira just to see the doctor. That was the amount they charged the last time we went, when Mama was having all those sweats, followed immediately by chills. That time, the doctors ran their tests and told her she was fine. 2,000 naira wasted and nothing fixed. Besides, Mama was certain it was nothing a little praying and Bible reading couldn't fix.

There was still a little glow from the sun in through our parlour, which was where we prayed every evening, kneeling on the tile floor:

MAMA: *Happy is the man whom God correcteth: therefore despise not thou the chastening of the Almighty:*

ADA: Her voice shook as she read.

MAMA: *For he maketh sore, and bindeth up: he woundeth, and his hands make whole. (shriek)*

ADA: And then she let out a piercing shriek: a sound I hope I never hear again for as long as I live.

The pain was somewhere on her back, between the upper shoulder and the lower back. She could feel it also in her front. Just like what she would expect a heart attack to be, except there was no indication that her heart was the part in which the crumbling was taking place.

In the end it was I who forced her to go to the hospital. We walked out the door early the next morning, taking small steps, my hands fastened securely around her waist. I should have told her I loved her. But how? Aside from prayers and practical exchanges, we rarely even talked those days just before she fell ill. I was busy with my studies, and she was busy with the market. And so there were silences, as if we no longer valued spoken words, as if spoken words were gaudy finishes on a delicate piece of art, unnecessary distractions from the masterpiece, whose substance was more meaningfully experienced if left unornamented.

Mama used to tell jokes and we'd laugh out loud as if we were the only people in the world. That Mama disappeared soon after Papa died and left us to fend for ourselves in a world where it was hard for a woman to do so honestly. Her mind was always on the market; how we would make money from the crops she sold to pay for this and for that. Of course, I understood her worry.

A bald-headed doctor unbuttoned her shirt. It was easy to see that there was redness and swelling in the area around her left shoulder. And where her sternum met the clavicle, just beneath her neck, there was a bulge. Next were the X-rays. There were no fractures in the bone but an abscess – a localized fluid collection – had formed in Mama's shoulder, a sign of infection in the area. She would have to be admitted to the hospital.

I stayed at home with her for weeks after she was discharged. My first day back at [the University] was about a month into Mama's illness. Outside of the lecture halls, I gazed at the

other students, the wealthy ones who wore shiny shoes on their feet and, on their ears, tiny Bluetooth headsets. The girls swayed their hips as they walked, hands dangling limply at their sides, as if they had no care in the world. Their patent leather handbags glistened, only a little less sparkly than the sequins on their stilettos. They drove Hondas and Jeeps. Their cellphones were always ringing, and they'd walk around saying, 'Darling' or 'Sweetheart', their voices turning more and more saccharine as they spoke. Such good humour must have been the soothing effect of having so much money, I thought, the effect of having so little to worry about. After all, there were only a few problems in life that money could not fix.

I was sitting on the cement steps of our classroom building when Njideka came to me. And so, I told her Mama was in pain, and the doctors did not know the cause.

NJIDEKA: You need good doctors. Private doctors, not those underpaid teaching hospital doctors who are always going on strike

ADA: I shook my head bitterly and rolled my eyes at her. We could not even afford the teaching hospital doctors. How would we afford the private doctors? *(to Njikdeka)* Mama says it's the curse of the black bird. We'll just stick to praying for now. *(to audience)* And I told her honestly, that we had no money.

NJIDEKA: *(commanding)* Go to the private doctors. I know a good one. I'll help you out.

ADA: Her voice was more vibrant than ever that afternoon. And I latched on to each and every one of her words, her intonations, because there was freedom in them, the way they rang out confidently, without restraint, without worry. Nothing like words between Mama and me.

primary patrons were the Yahoo Boys -- the ones who rolled into town in sleek cars and with pockets full of cash, even American dollars. She also told me about the *mugus*, the older men, oil executives. They bought her jewellery and paid for her recharge cards, sometimes as much as 20,000 naira per month!

NJIDEKA: The just want you to have private dinners with them. Sometimes, they just want to look at and have an intelligent conversation with a pretty woman. You're a pretty girl. Or at least you can be. And I know of a man who would love a girl like you. You could pay for your Mama's bills with the money.

ADA: *(angrily)* Abeg, comot from here! *(to audience)* [I was] shocked that she would even suggest such a thing for me. She could do as she pleased. But to go so far as to involve me in her sinful ways, that was another thing. *(to Njikeda)* God forbid!

She took out a handful of plastic-wrapped packets from a small box which she had brought from the room.

NJIDEKA: Condoms, just in case.

ADA: I didn't say I'd do it. It's sinful! *(to audience)* and I walked out the door. *(to audience)* We prayed again that night and Mama read again from Job.

MAMA: *Despise not thou the chastening of the Almighty: For he maketh sore, and bindeth up: he woundeth, and his hands make whole.*

ADA: That night, Mama asked that I helped her to bathe. She squeezed her eyes shut each time the cloth touched her skin. It didn't matter how gentle I was. That night, it was hard to tell what the droplets on her face were: tears from so much pain and suffering, or merely splashes of bath water.

would do it just one night. To get the money for Mama. I could take her to a specialist. If I did well, I could bring in 500 dollars or more. American dollars. Njideka had said that most of the men wanted nothing beyond dinner and maybe a kiss.

The man arrived in a BMW. It was supposed to be a simple dinner. But he stopped the car in a place that I did not recognize. He asked me to untie my dress. I began to cry, begging him to take me back home.

Then all his weight was on me. I screamed, but it was dark all around, empty space like an open field. Who could have heard? He dropped me off several blocks away and I walked home, many kilometres on bare feet, holding the sequined heels that Njideka had lent me. I found the stash of bills in my purse as I walked. One thousand dollars. All that money, because he must have known that I had never been with a man. *The work of the devil* -- but it was more than enough to pay for Mama's visits to a specialist.

I returned Mama was kneeling by the sofa, her arms and chest resting on its cushion, as if in the middle of praying. Mama! Do you hear me? Mama!' She did not respond. And then suddenly I was turning her around, checking for breath. And there was none. We buried her in the cemetery not too far from our flat, the same place where we buried Papa.

Sometimes I go to the cemetery to visit Mama and Papa. On days when I'm overwhelmed by shame, I go in the evening or at night, as if the darkness will somehow mask the shame. And I remember the days before Papa died, and if I listen carefully, sometimes I can hear Mama's laughter ringing out, somewhere far away from the cemetery.

Sometimes I think that if I were placed in a valley full of bones, I would create a new Eve, create her from a new set of bones. And I would cause breath to enter in, and this new Eve would live. [She] would walk amongst the trees of the garden and drink from the river. And again, she would eat the forbidden fruit. But she would not be cast away from the garden. She would be given the opportunity, just once, to ask for forgiveness. And she would be forgiven.

(she prays) ***For he maketh sore, and bindeth up: he woundeth, and his hands make whole.***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Chinelo Okparanta
Book: Happiness Like Water, Pg 67+
ISBN: 978-0544003453
Publisher: Mariner Books
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2013

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier

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